

SoHo (Rs 16,001 - Rs 30,000)

HP LaserJet 3052 All-in-One	Lexmark X342n	HP LaserJet 3055 All-in-One	Canon imageCLASS MF4150
			
Rs 20,999	Rs 23,900	Rs 24,499	Rs 25,995
Rs 2,961 / NA	Rs 4,500 / NA	Rs 2,961 / NA	Rs 3,995 / NA
Rs 1.48	Rs 0.75	Rs 1.48	Rs 2.00
+ Good software bundle - No fax, yet expensive	+ Good looks, economical - Slow in graphics documents	+ Fast copying, good scanner - Slow warm-up	+ Good print quality - High running costs
57.71	63.20	58.74	64.06
23.24	27.10	25.38	26.46
26.76	29.32	26.75	31.37
7.71	6.78	6.61	6.23
Printer-based	Printer-based	Printer-based	Printer-based
1200 x 1200	600 x 600	1200 x 1200	600 x 600
64 MB / x	64 MB / x	64 MB / x	32 MB / x
260 / 100	550 / 150	260 / 100	250 / 100
x / NA	✓ / 1	x / NA	✓ / 1
x	✓	x	✓
7000 / 2000 / NA	15000 / 6000 / NA	7000 / 2000 / NA	10000 / 2000 / NA
Flatbed	Flatbed and Sheet-fed	Flatbed and Sheet-fed	Flatbed and Sheet-fed
1200 x 1200	600 x 600	1200 x 1200	NA
A4 / 24	Legal / 24	A4 / 24	A4 / 24
✓ / 50	✓ / 50	✓ / 50	✓ / 35
x	✓	x	x
TWAIN, WIA	TWAIN, WIA	TWAIN, WIA	TWAIN, WIA
✓	✓	✓	✓
99	99	99	99
NA	✓	x	x
NA	NA	110 pages	256 pages
7	7	7	5
USB, LAN	USB, LAN	USB, LAN	USB
12.4 kg	16.33 kg	12.4 kg	13.4 kg
49.7 x 40.6	53 x 39.4	49.7 x 40.6	39 x 43.2
300 / 13 / 10	420 / 70 / 13	300 / 13 / 10	710 / NA / 3
6 / 7 / 6	5 / 7 / 7	6 / 7 / 6	7 / 7 / 6
8 / 5	4 / 7	8 / 5	8 / 7
HP ToolboxFX, Readiris Pro for PC and Mac	Presto! PageManager	HP ToolboxFX, Readiris Pro for PC and Mac	OmniPage SE OCR, Presto! PageManager
47.5 sec	48.3 sec	49.1 sec	15.7 sec
13.2 sec	11.4 sec	13.4 sec	8.5 sec
19.9 sec	11.4 sec	19.7 sec	8.8 sec
22.1 sec	179 sec	22 sec	12 sec
45.1 sec	32.1 sec	44.5 sec	14.4 sec
7 / 8	8 / 7	7 / 8	8 / 7.5
6 / 6	4 / 4	6 / 6	6 / 6
19.9 / 67.3	17.4 / 71.9	19.8 / 67.6	6.2 / 38.3
1	36	1	3
8.7 sec / 19.35	11.9 sec / 13.64	8.5 sec / 19.35	9.8 sec / 18.75
6	5	6	8

At The Podium

Taking into account all essential aspects—features, overall performance, price, and running costs—we can state our recommendations by saying which products won our awards.

In the Budget category, the Brother DCP-7010 and the HP LaserJet M1005 MFP fought it out for Gold. While the DCP-7010 offers great value as well as speed and performance, the M1005 has one of the best scanners in this test. We award the Brother DCP-7010 the *Digit Best Buy Gold* in this category for its better print quality and its unmatched cpp of 86 paise.

Nothing came close to the Brother MFC-7420 in terms of features in the SoHo category. It prints very fast and produces decent output. Monthly printer duty cycle is a healthy 10,000 prints. Fax-modem memory is as large as 500 pages, and cpp is just 61 paise—all meaning a *Digit Best Buy Gold* in this category!

The Canon imageCLASS MF4122 excels in print quality. The MFD with the lowest warm-up time in the entire test, it did not disappoint in speed. The scanner is very good in terms of capturing colour and detail, and it was fairly accurate in our OCR tests as well. Based on this, it receives the *Digit Best Buy Silver*.

Now for the SMB category: the Brother MFC-8860DN and MFC-8460N not only support a memory upgrade to 544 MB, but also a very large monthly duty cycle of 20,000 prints. These are fast performers, and print quality is decent. These are the only MFDs in this category with a Legal-size flatbed scanner. They feature all three interfaces—USB, Ethernet, and parallel port. Complementing all this is excellent speed and a cpp of just 61 paise. We award the Brother MFC-8860DN the *Digit Best Buy Gold*, and trailing a bit on features, the Brother MFC-8460N wins the *Digit Best Buy Silver*.

A Few Concluding Notes

If you mostly print large text documents, we believe you should choose a mono laser MFD. If you need to print colour photographs, there are colour laser MFDs, but are expensive; a colour inkjet makes more sense. Also consider the running costs: the average laser MFD consumes a lot of electricity—some heavy-duty ones can even go past the 1000 W mark.

The HP machines performed well; they produced the cleanest of all the prints, but their pricing was the problem.

We should also mention that HP MFDs have come up with little things that make for a better MFD—such as the inbuilt electronic stapler and the superb OCR application from IRIS. Also, the wide availability of their products and services across the length and breadth of the country—an important factor for any consumer—needs to be borne in mind.

The above could have led to the higher pricing, but HP's products did walk the talk.

We return to what we stated at the outset. If you're worrying about whether it's wise to go with an MFD rather than multiple devices, we say an MFD these days is more likely than not to prove reliable. ■

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